

Credit - Drishti Ias

Roadmap of India-Netherlands Strategic Partnership (2026-2030)



For Prelims: Netherlands , Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure , Dutch East India Company , Anaimangalam Copper Plates, Raja Raja Chola I

For Mains: India-Netherlands bilateral relations and strategic significance in the Indo-Pacific, India-EU relations

Source: PIB

Why in News?

The Prime Minister of India paid an official visit to the **Netherlands**. During this visit, both nations agreed to elevate their bilateral relationship to a "**Strategic Partnership**" and adopted the comprehensive "**Roadmap of India-Netherlands Strategic Partnership (2026-2030)**".

Summary

- India and the Netherlands upgraded their ties to a Strategic Partnership focused on water management, semiconductors, defence, green energy, Indo-Pacific cooperation, migration, and trade resilience.
- The partnership also highlights cultural diplomacy through the return of the Chola-era Leiden Copper Plates, while challenges remain in areas such as export controls, CBAM regulations, technology transfer, and strategic differences.



What are the Key Pillars of the Roadmap of India-Netherlands Strategic Partnership?

Political Dialogue & Institutional Mechanisms

- **Foreign Ministers' Mechanism:** A new annual review mechanism at the Foreign Ministers' level will be instituted to monitor the progress of the roadmap and provide strategic guidance.
- **High-Level Interactions:** Regular bilateral meetings between Heads of Government, Foreign Ministers, and Cabinet Ministers will be maintained, both via state visits and on the sidelines of multilateral forums.

Economic Cooperation and Value Chain Resilience

- **Joint Trade and Investment Committee (JTIC):** Leveraging annual JTIC meetings to expand trade and market access across high-potential sectors like electronics, telecommunications, infrastructure, pharmaceuticals, and iron & steel.
- **Fast Track Mechanism:** Periodic reviews of the existing **bilateral Fast Track Mechanism** to facilitate cross-border investment and resolve corporate bottlenecks.
- **Critical Raw Materials Partnership:** Launching a strategic partnership under a dedicated MoU to collaborate on **critical minerals** exploration, research, ESG standards, and value chain diversification.
- **SME & B2B Engagement:** Active **promotion of two-way investments**, joint ventures, and public-private partnerships, with a strong focus on enabling Small and Medium Enterprise (SME) participation.

Water, Agriculture, and Health (WAH)

- **Strategic Partnership on Water:** Commitment to renew the flagship water partnership (originally

signed in 2022) **until March 2027**, reviewed by a Ministerial Joint Working Group.

- **Ganga Basin & Urban Rivers:** Collaboration on integrated water resource management, coastal zone management, flood resilience, and restoring water quality in the **Ganga Basin**.
 - This includes creating **Urban River Management Plans** using the 'Water as Leverage' approach.
- **Disaster-Resilient Infrastructure:** Partnering with the India-led **Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure (CDRI)** to develop climate-and-disaster-resilient urban water frameworks globally.
- **Ag-Tech Innovation:** Upgrading the Joint Agriculture Working Group and expanding agricultural technology collaboration, including the **establishment of Clean Plant Centres to boost sustainable agriculture**.
- **Public Health & One Health:** Strengthening research on cross-border infectious diseases, **Anti-Microbial Resistance (AMR)** , and digital health via collaboration between the Dutch National Institute for Public Health and the Environment (RIVM) and the **Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR)**.

Emerging Technologies and Education

- **Semiconductor "Brain Bridge":** A bilateral academic and R&D initiative between India and the Netherlands designed to accelerate research, innovation, and advanced skills development in semiconductor technologies
 - Linking the **Indian Semiconductor Mission (ISM)** with the **Dutch Semicon Competence Centre** to foster startups, scale-ups, and trusted hardware supply chains.
- **Education:** Signed an MoU on Higher Education and celebrated institutional tie-ups between major Indian and Dutch universities.

Energy Transition and Maritime Development

- **Green and Digital Sea Corridor:** Formulating an action plan to create an environmentally **sustainable, digitally integrated maritime corridor** between the two nations.
 - This corridor will facilitate **India's green hydrogen exports** directly into European markets.
- **Global Alliances:** Working together under multilateral platforms like the **Global Biofuels Alliance** , **International Solar Alliance (ISA)** , and the **Integrated Biorefineries Mission**.

Defence and Security Cooperation

- **Joint Tri-Services Interactions:** Establishing structured interactions between the respective Ministries of Defence to coordinate military-to-military cooperation.
- **Defence Industrial Roadmap:** Facilitating institutional collaboration between the **Society of Indian Defence Manufacturers (SIDM)** and the **Netherlands Industry for Defence and Security (NIDV)** for co-development of platforms and equipment.
- **Logistics & Indo-Pacific Convergence:** Examining the feasibility of a **Mutual Logistic Support Agreement (MLSA)** .
 - The Netherlands will also expand its participation in the **Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative (IPOI)** and the **Information Fusion Centre-Indian Ocean Region (IFC-IOR)**.
- **Counter-Terrorism & Cyber Security:** Strengthening bilateral cyber dialogues, expanding information-sharing on threat assessments, and working toward concluding a **Mutual Legal Assistance Treaty (MLAT)** and a new Extradition Treaty.

Culture, Mobility & Heritage

- **Migration:** Signed the **MoU on Migration and Mobility** to facilitate fair mobility for students and highly skilled professionals while combating irregular migration.
- **Heritage Restitution:** Welcomed the historic return of the **Chola-era Anaimangalam copper plates** from the University of Leiden to India.
- **Museums & Arts:** Expanded cultural exchanges, including mutual exhibitions involving Amrita Sher-Gil and Van Gogh, and finalized an MoU to develop the **National Maritime Heritage Complex (NMHC)** in Lothal, Gujarat.

The Leiden Plates (Anaimangalam Copper Plates)

- **Leiden Plates:** The artefacts consist of **21 large and 3 small copper plates fastened with a royal bronze ring** .
 - The plates were taken to the Netherlands in the 18th century by Florentius Camper during **Dutch** control of Nagapattinam.
 - India's restitution claim later gained support from the **24th session of the Intergovernmental Committee on Return and Restitution** , which recognised India as the rightful country of origin.
- **Anaimangalam Grant:** The plates formally record the grant of the Anaimangalam village to a **Buddhist vihara (the Chulamanivarma Vihara)**.
 - This monastery was built by King Sri Mara Vijayotunga Varman of the Srivijaya Kingdom (modern-day Java, Indonesia).
 - The grant was originally vowed orally by **Raja Raja Chola I** and physically executed by his son, **Rajendra Chola I** , showcasing profound religious syncretism and Southeast Asian maritime diplomacy.
- **Linguistic and Structural Composition:** The words carved into the copper sheets are divided into two distinct languages based on their function:
 - The elaborate royal genealogy is written in **Sanskrit (using the Grantha script)** , while the minute operational details of land boundaries, tax exemptions (**pariharas**), and local assembly duties (**Sabha or Ur**) are written in **Tamil** .
- **Symbolism of the Royal Insignia:** The heavy binding seal depicts the **Chola Tiger seated upright alongside the Pandya Twin Fish and the Chera Bow** , visually symbolizing Chola suzerainty and military triumph over rival Tamil Muvendhar (Three Crowned Kings).
 - Functioning as unalterable legal state records, the **earliest known example is the Sogaura Copperplate (Mauryan Era)** , which distinctly records state-sponsored famine relief efforts in the **Prakrit language and Brahmi script** .
- **Other Landmark Chola Charters:**
 - **Karandai Plates:** Massive 57-plate set detailing **Rajendra I's military expeditions** and extensive Brahmadeya grants.
 - **Tiruvallangadu Plates:** Records **Rajendra I's famous expedition to the Ganges** river.
 - **Anbil Plates:** Issued by **Sundara Chola** , offering foundational genealogical details of early Chola rulers.



What are the Key Challenges in the Strategic Partnership?

- **Defence and Strategic Divergences: India's push for Aatmanirbhar Bharat and mandatory Technology Transfer (ToT) may conflict with the Netherlands' private, IP-driven defence industry model under NIDV .**
 - Strategic priorities also differ, as the Netherlands remains focused on [NATO](#) and European security , while India prioritizes the Indo-Pacific and Himalayan region . Negotiating a Mutual Logistic Support Agreement (MLSA) will therefore be complex due to India's emphasis on strategic autonomy .
- **High-Tech Export Controls** : India-Netherlands semiconductor cooperation faces hurdles because Dutch company **ASML** is subject to global export restrictions, especially US-led controls on advanced chip technology.
 - Even if joint R&D succeeds, India still faces major infrastructural gaps, such as **high capital costs, uninterrupted electricity, and ultra-pure water requirements** needed for semiconductor fabrication plants.
- **Economic and Regulatory Frictions: The proposed Green and Digital Sea Corridor may face obstacles from the EU's [Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism \(CBAM\)](#) if Indian environmental standards do not match EU norms.**
 - Indian agricultural exports also continue to face strict [Sanitary and Phytosanitary \(SPS\)](#) regulations in Europe despite institutional cooperation between Indian and Dutch food safety agencies.
- **Implementation and Domestic Political Constraints:** The India-Netherlands Migration and Mobility MoU may face difficulties because of rising anti-immigration sentiment and protectionist politics in Europe.
 - Similarly, cooperation in water management projects such as [Namami Gange](#) and the [Kalpasar Project](#) often suffers from delays due to coordination issues between Dutch firms and India's multi-layered bureaucracy involving central, state, and local authorities.

- **Geopolitical Alignment in the Indo-Pacific:** The Netherlands issued its **Indo-Pacific guidelines in 2020** , recognizing India as a pivotal partner for ensuring a **free, open, and inclusive Indo-Pacific region** .
- **Asymmetric Trade Dominance:** The Netherlands is India's **11 th largest merchandise trading partner globally and the largest within the European Union (EU)** , with total bilateral trade reaching **USD 27.341 billion in FY 2023-2024** .
- **Major Export Hub:** India enjoys a substantial **trade surplus of USD 17.393 billion** with the Netherlands, making it **India's largest merchandise export destination in Europe** .
 - India's **major exports** to the Netherlands include mineral fuels and oils, electrical machinery, organic chemicals, pharmaceuticals, iron and steel, and apparel.
 - Major **imports** from the Netherlands include machinery and boilers, optical and precision instruments, electrical equipment, pharmaceuticals, plastics, and organic chemicals.
- **Core Pillars of Cooperation (WAH):** Bilateral institutional mechanisms prioritize **Water, Agriculture, and Health (WAH)** as the three core sectors of technological and commercial engagement.
- **Strategic Water Partnership:** Upgraded to a **Ministerial-level Joint Working Group (JWG) on Water in 2021** , the Netherlands actively collaborates on flagship Indian sub-national projects, including the **Namami Gange Programme (Uttar Pradesh)** , flood management in Kerala, and conservation initiatives in Tamil Nadu.
- **Global Climate and Clean Energy Architecture:** The Netherlands is a key partner in India-led global climate platforms, having signed the **International Solar Alliance (ISA) Framework Agreement in 2018** and joined the **Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure (CDRI) in 2021** .
 - A specialized **MoU on Renewable Energy** was signed in September 2024.
- **Cultural Footprint:** The Netherlands hosts **the second-largest Indian Diaspora in Europe** , while housing "**The Gandhi Centre**" (**ICCR Cultural Centre**) in **The Hague** since 2011 to spearhead cultural diplomacy.

What Measures can Further Deepen India-Netherlands Relations?

- **Navigating Export Control Regimes:** To bypass unilateral high-tech export controls (such as US-led restrictions affecting Dutch firm **ASML**), India and the Netherlands should establish a **Joint Tech-Compliance Working Group** .
 - This group can create legal ring-fences for joint R&D, ensuring compliance while securing specialized equipment transfers for non-military applications.
- **CBAM Mitigation Framework:** To protect the proposed **Green and Digital Sea Corridor** , India and the Netherlands must co-develop a **Green Hydrogen and Low-Carbon Certification Scheme** .
 - Aligning Indian production standards with the **EU's Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM)** will ensure tariff-free entry for Indian green energy into the Rotterdam port.
 - Establishing **pre-clearance certification labs** at major Indian ports will reduce rejection rates for Indian agricultural exports under European **Sanitary and Phytosanitary (SPS)** measures.
- **Hybrid Intellectual Property (IP) Models:** Bridge the gap between India's **Aatmanirbhar Bharat** (Technology Transfer requirements) and the private, IP-driven model of the Netherlands Industry for Defence and Security (**NIDV**).
 - Both nations should adopt a "**Co-development and Joint Export**" framework where IP is jointly held for specific regional variants targeting third-party markets in the Indo-Pacific.

- **Immigration Legal Safeguards:** By implementing blockchain-verified digital talent registries, both nations can ensure transparent, high-skilled professional transit while completely mitigating irregular migration.

Drishti Mains Question:

Q. Discuss the significance of the India-Netherlands Strategic Partnership 2026-2030 in the context of India's Indo-Pacific policy

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the central focus of the India-Netherlands Strategic Partnership?

It focuses on trade, water, agriculture, health, semiconductors, defence, clean energy, migration, and cultural diplomacy.

2. Why are the Leiden Copper Plates important?

They are Chola-era copper plates returned from Leiden, recording the Anaimangalam village grant and reflecting Chola maritime and cultural links with Southeast Asia.

3. What are the main challenges in India-Netherlands cooperation?

Major challenges include defence technology transfer issues, semiconductor export controls, CBAM, SPS barriers, and implementation delays caused by bureaucracy.

4. Why is the water partnership significant for India?

It supports river basin management, flood resilience, urban water planning, and climate-resilient infrastructure through institutional cooperation.

[Watch Video on YouTube:

▶ <https://www.youtube.com/embed/p88tEIKSw10>

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UPSC Civil Services Examination Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. Consider the following statements: (2023)

The 'Stability and Growth Pact' of the European Union is a treaty that

1. limits the levels of the budgetary deficit of the countries of the European Union
2. makes the countries of the European Union to share their infrastructure facilities
3. enables the countries of the European Union to share their technologies

How many of the above statements are correct

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

Ans: (a)

Q. The term 'Digital Single Market Strategy' seen in the news refers to (2017)

- (a) ASEAN
- (b) BRICS
- (c) EU
- (d) G20

Ans:(c)

Q. 'European Stability Mechanism', sometimes seen in the news is an (2016)

- (a) agency created by EU to deal with the impact of millions of refugees arriving from Middle East
- (b) agency of EU that provides financial assistance to eurozone countries
- (c) agency of EU to deal with all the bilateral and multilateral agreements on trade
- (d) agency of EU to deal with the conflicts arising among the member countries

Ans: (b)

Mains

Q. The expansion and strengthening of NATO and a stronger US-Europe strategic partnership works well for India.' What is your opinion about this statement? Give reasons and examples to support your answer. (2023)

CIC Exemption of BCCI from the RTI Act, 2005



Source: IE

The **Central Information Commission (CIC)** has ruled that the **Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI)** does not qualify as a “**public authority**” under the **Right to Information (RTI) Act, 2005**.

- The CIC reversed its 2018 order, which had earlier declared the BCCI a public authority under the RTI Act.
- **Interpretation of Section 2(h) of the RTI Act:** The CIC held that the BCCI fails to satisfy the statutory definition of a “public authority” under **Section 2(h)** because it is a **private society registered** under Tamil Nadu law, rather than an entity established by Parliament, state legislatures, or an executive notification.
- **Substantial Financing vs. Tax Concessions:** The Commission explicitly clarified that **tax exemptions or statutory concessions** available generally under law do not constitute “**substantial financing**” by the government (a critical legal threshold required to bring an independent body under the RTI Act).
- **Absence of State Control:** The ruling highlighted that the government exercises no meaningful administrative control over the BCCI, plays no **role in appointing its office-bearers**, and does not fund its multi-crore market-driven operations (IPL media rights, sponsorships, etc.).
- **Reliance on Judicial Precedents:** The CIC grounded its decision in established jurisprudence:
 - **Thalappalam Service Cooperative Bank v. State of Kerala (2013):** The Supreme Court held that bodies receiving indirect benefits or limited government aid cannot automatically be treated as “public authorities” under the RTI Act.
 - **Zee Telefilms v. Union of India (2005):** The Court ruled that the Board of Control for Cricket in India is not “State” under **Article 12** of the Constitution despite performing public functions.
 - **Dalco Engineering v. Satish Prabhakar Padhye (2010):** The Supreme Court clarified that substantial government financing or control is necessary for an entity to fall within statutory public accountability frameworks.
 - The Commission noted that the Supreme Court's verdict in **BCCI v. Cricket Association of Bihar (2016)** mandated internal governance reforms but stopped short of declaring the BCCI a public authority.
 - The order observed that the transparency recommendations made by the **Justice R.M. Lodha Committee (2015)** and the **Law Commission of India's 275th Report (2018)** on transparency and accountability were termed merely advisory and cannot override the explicit statutory language enacted by Parliament.
- **Caution Against Regulatory Overreach:** The CIC concluded that superimposing public-sector administrative oversight frameworks **onto autonomous, market-driven sports entities** could create unintended disruptions in a finely balanced economic structure, noting that government control does not automatically guarantee fairness.

Right to Information (RTI) Act, 2005

- The RTI Act, 2005, empowers citizens to access data held by public authorities, thereby upholding the

spirit of [Article 19\(1\)\(a\) of the Constitution](#) . It applies to all levels of government and public authorities, but not to private bodies unless they qualify as a “public authority” under **Section 2(h) of the RTI Act, 2005** .

- It permits the disclosure of exempted information if the **public interest** outweighs the harm to protected interests.
- The Act exempts information affecting India’s sovereignty, security, strategic interests, or foreign relations.

Read more: [20 years of RTI Act, 2005](#)